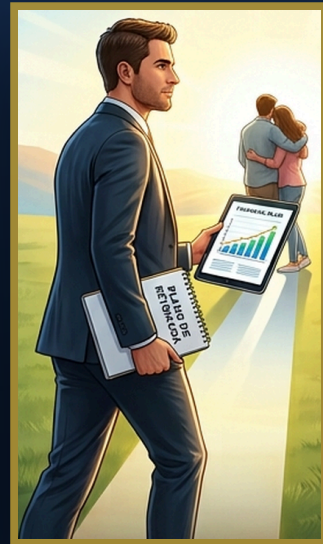


— THE ACTION PLAN —

# RISE, FALL, AND COMEBACK



## PART 2 · THE SURVIVAL AND COMEBACK MANUAL

The mistakes that destroy fortunes, the triage that organizes the chaos, and the strategies to rebuild your financial life and your marriage.

WRITTEN BY

JOSÉ RODRIGO

# THE SURVIVAL AND COMEBACK MANUAL

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Rise, Fall, and Comeback — Part 2

The practical method to get out of debt, protect your family, and take  
back control.

**JOSÉ RODRIGO**

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## INTRODUCTION

# Welcome to Part 2

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If you made it this far, it is because my story resonated with yours. You felt the weight of silence, the pain of financial betrayal, and the despair of seeing your own name threatened. Part 1 of this book was about my life; this Part 2 is about your rescue. What you will read from now on is the practical method, forged in fire and sweat, that I am using to rebuild my financial stability and protect my family. There is no room for pretty theories here. The market is cold, interest rates are merciless, and to get out of the hole, **you need to stop digging**.

# The 5 Biggest Financial Mistakes I Made (and How to Avoid Them)

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**E**xperience is a cruel teacher: first she gives you the test, and only afterwards teaches you the lesson. Looking back at my journey, the financial abyss was not created overnight. It was built by small decisions that, at the time, seemed harmless or well-intentioned. If you want to protect your assets and your peace of mind, engrave these five golden rules.

### **Mistake 1: Lending your name to friends**

Your personal and business credit are the most sacred tools of your professional life. They have no feelings. The biggest mistake a good-hearted man can make is mixing gratitude and friendship with financial guarantees. When you lend your name or your credit so a friend can take merchandise or take on debt, you are not helping; you are assuming 100% of the risk of someone else's incompetence. Help your friends with advice, with contacts, or even with money you do not expect to get back. But never, under any circumstance, sign a paper or extend credit guaranteeing someone else's debt.

### **Mistake 2: Investing with borrowed money (suicidal leverage)**

The mathematics of fast money is the favorite illusion of those who are earning well. Believing you can borrow money (from a bank or, worse, from loan sharks) at interest rate X, to invest in a "miraculous" opportunity that yields Y, is the fastest road to bankruptcy. There is no free lunch in the market. When the investment turns to dust or gets frozen, the returns disappear, but the interest clock on your debt keeps ticking against you 24 hours a day. **Only invest money that is yours.**

### **Mistake 3: Long-term financing**

Easy, stretched-out credit is a psychological trap. When you split a car or any asset into 48, 60, or 72 installments, the payment seems to fit today's budget, but you are selling your future cash flow. You do not know how the market, your company, or your health will be four years from now. The long term leaves you vulnerable to any setback. Extended financing erodes your room to maneuver. If you cannot pay for it within a short, safe term, you cannot afford that asset yet.

### **Mistake 4: The "half-sole" loan (pay everything off, or don't do it!)**

When the rope tightens, the natural instinct is to take out a loan to patch the most urgent holes. The fatal mistake here is borrowing an amount that covers only part of the debts. If you owe five places and take a loan to pay only two, you have just created a sixth creditor while the interest on the other three keeps running. The rule for debt consolidation is binary: if you take out a loan, do the exact math to unify and settle absolutely every other obligation, ending up with a single installment that fits your pocket. **If the loan does not cover everything, do not take it.** You will only worsen the bleeding.

## ■ **Mistake 5: Using credit cards to raise cash**

A credit card should be only a convenience tool, never an emergency credit line. Taking cash advances on the card, using apps to pay bills with the card for a fee, or using it to inject quick money into your checking account is signing your own financial death sentence. Revolving credit card interest rates are among the most lethal that exist — in Brazil, they easily exceed 400% a year. The money you "raise" today to solve one problem becomes an unpayable monster the following month.

## Mapping the Chaos (The Financial Triage)

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**T**he first instinct of someone drowning in debt is panic. When the bomb exploded and I found myself with combined liabilities of R\$ 270,000 (about US\$ 50,000) — split between my personal name, my company, and the parallel market —, the urge was to take every incoming dollar and fire it in all directions, trying to put out the blaze.

But a sales professional knows that effort without strategy is just wasted energy.

I sat in front of the computer, opened a spreadsheet, and listed absolutely everything I owed. Looking at that final number hurt, but it brought clarity. I understood that, to climb out of the hole while earning well, I needed to stop acting out of despair and start thinking like the chief financial officer of my own life.

I created what I call **the Chaos Triage**. I divided my real debts into five categories of urgency. This is the golden rule: you must never treat all debts with the same weight.

### 1. The Black Level (the psychological risk and family peace)

**My case:** R\$ 40,000 (about US\$ 7,400) in the hands of a loan shark.

**The strategy:** This is category zero. The absolute priority. The bank can wait, the government can wait, but the parallel market does not wait. The interest here follows no law — it is predatory, and the collection methods attack your mind and the safety of your home. Every single extra resource I can generate from new sales of large contracts, bonuses, or drastic cuts in the household budget has one destination only: paying down that principal. The number one goal of any indebted person is to pull their own head out of the parallel market's guillotine.

### 2. The Shield (what protects your income)

**My case:** The car loan and an ongoing settlement with the credit union (solar panels and a personal loan).

**The strategy:** The car is not a luxury; it is my prospecting and work tool. Without it, I do not visit clients, I do not close contracts, and revenue drops to zero. The credit union settlement, having already been renegotiated, has strict rules — breaking it now would trigger immediate account freezes. This category is your "Shield." It must be the first thing paid every month, religiously. **Protect whatever generates your money.**

### 3. The Financial Cancer (the banking elimination priority)

**My case:** Two credit cards (a bank card and a store card).

**The strategy:** Revolving credit card interest in Brazil easily exceeds 400% a year. It is a cancer that metastasizes in your account. Paying only the minimum, you have already lost the game. The goal is to stop

using them immediately and build a negotiation plan to slice up or settle that balance as soon as the "Black Level" is resolved. Eliminate these cards from your life. Cut the root of high interest.

#### ■ 4. The "Cheap" Money (the corporate debt)

**My case:** A government-subsidized small-business credit line (in Brazil, called Pronampe) and a business loan (totaling about R\$ 110,000 / US\$ 20,000).

**The strategy:** A subsidized credit line means interest far below any personal loan on the market. The desperate business owner's big mistake is trying to pay off those installments early. Do not do it. This is controlled debt. Pay only the monthly installment and keep your free cash flow to kill the more expensive, more dangerous debts.

#### ■ 5. The Emotional Debt (the most dangerous creditor for the mind)

**My case:** The loan from my mother.

**The strategy:** Financially speaking, this is the debt with the lowest interest (usually zero). But emotionally, it is the one that weighs the most. The mistake is borrowing from the bank (at sky-high interest) to pay back family. A real man sits down with his mother, lays out the comeback plan with transparency, and says: "I am focusing on eliminating the most dangerous debt and protecting my car so I can keep working, but I have set aside a fixed, untouchable monthly amount to pay you back little by little." **Pay the bank with mathematics; pay your family with dialogue and honor.**

#### ■ Beware of the "Maintenance Illusion" (the trap of interest without amortization)

There is a silent mistake I made in the desperation of not letting the rope snap: agreeing to pay only the monthly interest on a heavy debt to "buy time." In my case, I reached a point where I was paying almost a thousand reais every month (about US\$ 180) to a parallel-market creditor, and absolutely not one cent of that amount reduced the R\$ 40,000 principal.

The math is cruel. Paying R\$ 960 a month on R\$ 40,000 means 2.4% a month. If I spent the next five years paying only that, I would have handed over more than R\$ 57,000 (about US\$ 10,500) to that person and would still owe the same R\$ 40,000. **Paying interest only is the same as paying rent to live in hell.** You bleed your monthly cash flow, compromise your family's livelihood, and the debt remains intact, laughing in your face.

The rule here is non-negotiable: you must force an amortization negotiation. Every extra amount that comes in — a company bonus, the commission from a new corporate sale (like the solar energy contracts I started closing), or the sale of an asset — must be thrown directly at the principal to bring the balance down. Save up R\$ 5,000 or R\$ 10,000 (US\$ 1,000–2,000), sit down with the creditor, and say: "Here is this amount to reduce the principal — now recalculate my interest on what is left." Every blow to the principal lowers your monthly interest bill. **If you do not reduce the principal, the debt will be eternal.**

When you structure the chaos this way, the impossible becomes a daily action plan. The money from my high income stopped turning to dust and became ammunition aimed at the right targets.



# The Conversation that Saves a Marriage

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I have closed contracts worth hundreds of thousands. I have negotiated with directors, city governments, and hospitals. I have faced tough clients, defaulters, and aggressive competitors. But no negotiating table in my life ever scared me as much as the table in my own kitchen. The hardest conversation in the life of a man in debt is not with the bank, nor with the loan shark. It is with the person who sleeps beside him.

I know the price of silence because I have paid every cent of it. I lied to Vivian about the size of the loan. I refinanced her car to pay debts that were not mine. And with every omission, I gained one day of false peace and accumulated a month of future war. If you are living this, engrave this truth: **your wife will not find out "if" — she will find out "when."** And there is a brutal difference between the truth told by you, with a plan in hand, and the truth discovered by her, with a collection letter in the mailbox.

This chapter is the script for that conversation. Treat it as the most important sale of your life: the product is the rebuilding of trust, and the client is the person who loves you most.

### Step 1: Understand what is really at stake

The problem was never just the money. Debt can be renegotiated, amortized, paid. Broken trust has no installment plan. When a wife finds out on her own, her question is not "how much do we owe?" — it is **"what else are you hiding from me?"**. That is the question that destroys marriages. The spontaneous conversation, however bad the number presented, kills that question before it is born.

### Step 2: Prepare as if for the most important meeting of the year

No salesman walks into a decisive meeting without a proposal. Before the conversation, do the homework from Chapter 10: the complete Chaos Triage, on paper. Every debt listed, with amounts, interest rates, and priorities. And, alongside them, the plan: what you are already doing, which extra income streams you are building, what the goal is for each month. **You will not present a problem. You will present a problem with the solution already in motion.** That difference changes everything in the mind of the listener.

### Step 3: Choose the moment and the ground

No kids around, no television on, no rush and — fundamental — not in the middle of a fight. Do not use the truth as a weapon, and do not let it slip out in a moment of anger. Set the moment yourself. A Saturday morning, the girls at their grandmother's, coffee on the table. The setting of the conversation should say: "this is important and I prepared for it."

### Step 4: The script — the whole truth, all at once

Start by owning it, without detours and without outsourcing the blame: **"I made mistakes, I hid them, and today I am going to tell you everything."** Do not start with the friend who betrayed you, nor with the

investment that collapsed — that comes later, as context. The responsibility is yours, and it must appear first.

Then deliver the entire truth. All the numbers, at once. The worst thing in the world is truth by eyedropper: every new revelation in the following weeks reopens the wound and proves you are still hiding things. If the number is 270 thousand, the number spoken is 270 thousand — not 30 thousand today and the rest when courage comes. **I did this the wrong way once. Do not repeat my mistake.**

Next, turn the page to the plan: the Triage on paper, what is already being paid, the new income streams, the realistic timeline. And close by asking for what really matters: **"I am not asking for your forgiveness today. I am asking you to be my team in this comeback."**

### ■ **Step 5: Withstand the reaction without defending yourself**

She will be angry. She will cry, or she will go silent — which sometimes hurts more. She has that right, because the lie was also against her. Do not argue back, do not justify yourself, do not say "but I did it for us." Listen. Her reaction is not the verdict on the marriage; it is the legitimate price of delayed truth. The rebuilding begins the next day, and the next, and the next.

### ■ **Step 6: Establish permanent transparency**

The conversation is not the end; it is the foundation. From it, create the ritual I call the **monthly couple's meeting**: once a month, the two of you sit in front of the spreadsheet. What came in, what went out, what was paid down, what remains. Bank passwords stop being secrets. Any financial decision above an agreed amount becomes a decision for two. Trust is not rebuilt with promises — it is rebuilt with access.

And here I must be honest with you, reader, as I promised to be from the first page. As I write this chapter, there is a part of me whispering the opposite path: **"solve everything first, in silence, and tell her later, when the storm has passed."** It is tempting. After all, my family did not create these debts — why hand them this pain? I walked into these problems alone, and something inside me insists I must walk out of them alone. Maybe you are making that same inner deal right now.

But I know the interest rate on that deal, because I pay it every day: the swallowed bitterness, the rehearsed smile, the weight of living as two different characters inside the same house. And I know the greatest risk of all: **truth has an expiration date when it depends only on our silence.** A collection letter, a phone call, a comment from a third party — and it reaches the ones we love through the worst possible door, with no plan, no context, and without our voice. The script you have just read is the map I wrote first for myself. It is my commitment, registered in these pages: that conversation will happen — through my voice, not through discovery. May yours happen the same way.

# Accelerating Revenue with B2B Intelligence

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Organizing your debts stops the bleeding, but it does not fill the tank. To climb out of the hole in years instead of decades, there is only one lever at your disposal: increasing revenue. And the fastest way to increase revenue is not working more hours — it is working on bigger sales. This chapter is the summary of more than twenty years of corporate selling, from the pharmacy counter to the contracts that sustain my comeback today.

### 1. Stop hunting ants: the volume mindset

When I sold boxes of medicine at the counter, one by one, my ceiling was the size of the line. When I took over the public procurement department, the same effort as a single customer interaction became an order worth thousands. The department that generated 10 to 12 thousand a month reached more than 250 thousand a month — **not because I worked twenty times harder, but because every "yes" was worth twenty times more**. The question that changes the game is: who, in your region, buys what you sell in large quantities and with frequency? City governments, hospitals, companies, residential complexes, vehicle fleets. That is where the speed of your comeback lives.

### 2. Map the high-consumption clients

Market intelligence is not an expensive tool; it is a method. Make a list of the potential large clients in your industry and answer, for each one: What do they buy? From whom do they buy today? How much do they spend per month? When does the current contract expire? Who makes the purchasing decision? An ordinary salesman knows the product; **a high-value salesman knows the client before shaking their hand**. I closed enormous contracts simply because I knew the client's pain before the competitor even knew the client existed.

### 3. The routine of those who truly chase

Prospecting has no glamour, and whoever tells you otherwise has never prospected. My real routine is multichannel and laborious: researching clients on the internet, knocking door to door, making many phone calls, and sending many messages on WhatsApp — every day, without picking a favorite channel, using all of them at the same time. Is it an exhausting process? It is. But nothing that stops someone whose goal is bigger than the fatigue. **Prospecting is relationship, truly chasing, and executing what needs to be done**. The client who does not answer the message picks up the call; the one who does not pick up the call opens the door. Consistency beats idle talent: whoever makes fifty contacts a day does not depend on the luck of any single one.

### 4. Sell the solution to the problem, not the product

Nobody with decision-making power has time for a catalog. In the corporate approach, the conversation that opens doors starts with the client's problem: "you spend X per month on this; I can deliver the same

result for less" or "I solve the shortage your current supplier leaves behind." It was like that at the counter, it was like that in public bids, and it is like that today in solar energy: **I do not sell panels, I sell a smaller electricity bill.** Find the number that keeps your client awake at night and present yourself as the solution to that number.

## ■ 5. Build recurring revenue: the salary you create for yourself

A one-off sale pays for the month; a subscription pays for the year. When I set up my operation of subscription-based solar energy, mobile plans, and vehicle insurance, I was not just adding commissions: I was building an income that repeats every month without depending on a new sale. For someone in debt, recurring revenue is pure gold, because it turns debt payments into something predictable. Look in your market for what can be sold by contract, by subscription, or by continuous supply — and prioritize those sales over one-off ones.

## ■ 6. The discipline of the cannon shots

Selling more is useless if the new money evaporates into lifestyle. Here is the rule that connects this chapter to the entire Chaos Triage: **every extra income is born with a destination.** A new commission, a bonus, a closed contract — that money does not enter the household budget; it becomes a "cannon shot" against the principal of the most dangerous debt. It is the combination of the two ends — organizing the liabilities (Chapter 10) and accelerating revenue (this chapter) — that shortens the crossing from decades to years.

Sales pulled me out of hunger when I was a boy carrying boxes. And it is sales, again, pulling me out of the abyss now. The skill that feeds you is the same one that rescues you. **Use it with method, and the hole that seems eternal gets an end date.**

## CONCLUSION

# The New Beginning

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I do not write this conclusion from the top of the mountain. I write it from the middle of the climb — boots covered in mud, spreadsheet open, installments still coming due. And that is exactly why this book has value: it is not the romanticized story of someone who has already won; it is the honest map of someone who is winning, one month at a time.

The boy who ate roasted chicken skin became the man who earned big, fell through blind trust, and today rebuilds everything with method. If there is one synthesis of everything you have read in these two parts, it is this: **the rise is built with work, the fall is avoided with boundaries, and the comeback is conquered with truth and strategy.**

Protect your name as your most sacred asset. Never invest what is not yours. Organize the chaos before attacking it. Break the silence before it breaks your home. And use your talent — whatever it is — as a rescue tool, not just a means of living.

My debt has an end date. The complete truth has a seat reserved at my table. And my greatest project does not fit in a spreadsheet: it is bringing back the man I have always been — upbeat, charismatic, happy, full of plans — whole again for my family, which has always been and will always be my main plan. Total protection for them. My story, which for so long was my shame, is now my working tool — because if it stops a single reader from signing the guarantee I signed, every page will have been worth it.

See you at the top. Again. **And this time, for good.**

— José Rodrigo

RISE, FALL, AND COMEBACK

## COMING SOON — PART 3: THE TOTAL COMEBACK

The book you have just read was written from the middle of the climb. The next one will be written from the top.

In **Part 3 — The Total Comeback**, I will tell the ending I am building day after day: the whole story laid bare with Vivian, face to face, with no number hidden. My name clean. The debts settled, one by one, with the method you learned in this manual. And the total recovery of my family life — trust back, the man back, a home at peace.

**God willing.**

You followed the rise. You felt the fall. You learned the plan.  
Now, get ready to witness the comeback — **in full**.